The Institute View on The Systems Experiment

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The Systems Experiment was undoubtedly a failure on many parts. While this was the first event in the history of the Institute, it cannot be dismissed how the planning, communication, and organisation was not up to the expected standard of its participants and IMS members.

This editorial should not be taken as an attack on its lead organiser, Turtle, but a reflection on the event that started a domino effect of discussion.

Communication should have been much clearer and much more concise. Many players who proposed systems early on were later told that this was made not mandatory. The 4000-word-long manual contains a lot of information that is presented in a difficult-to-digest format for everyday players. Questions about what counts as a system, or even what category a system comes under, required clarification on a case-by-case basis. This was exhausting for players and organisers.

Putting some decisions on the event's mechanics down to player votes is not an inherently bad thing – in fact, it should be done to as far an extent as is practical, in line with the IMS' democratic principles. However, key decisions such as grief protection in the nether or whether teams should remain in their current form (where players invite their friends to be on the same team), is best handled in-house.

For an event focused on building and using systems, griefing is a question that requires nuance and care. Certain limitations could be in place to protect systems that took time and effort to build, while allowing military systems to destroy the landscape in a war.

The staff team required to manage such a large scale event that included a multi-step application process must be large in number. Unfortunately, despite attempts to recruit organisers, only two or three were ever active, and could not help with in-game issues.

Future IMS events must be simple enough to be organised smoothly and effectively or be able to maintain a large, active staff team to help organise the core of the event and answer questions.

One lesson the Institute must learn from TSE is that one small mistake or miscommunication to the organisers can seem like a confusing, contradictory decision to players.

The last straw for the Systems Experiment as a whole was the drop in engagement and player count towards the end of the event. Although intended to be a two-month-long event, it was cut short and ended in late July. The issues in communication no doubt had an effect on this, but it's more helpful to consider another factor.

Because of the fact that the server ran 24/7, players logged on at different times in their own friend groups. Despite efforts within both teams to agree on a specific time to log on, because players weren't obliged to play at specific time slots, it was difficult to increase – and maintain – activity.

Depending on the event, a 24/7 set-up may be more beneficial, and organisers must not corner themselves into choosing one and sticking to it for life. However, there are also benefits for session-based events, which are especially pronounced if the gameplay focuses on player-to-player interactions.

If the IMS decides to plan a long-term, large-scale event, it must take its time to effectively plan, organise, and communicate clearly.

People and time are the Institute's friends when it comes to big projects like TSE, and it is vital it manipulates its already limited resources carefully.

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